the next Chief. I added that I did not think that "it would go down well with the army", an expression of prejudice rather than a remark sustainable by either logic or precept.'

After landing in Delhi, Thapar drove off immediately to meet the prime minister while Palit went to additional defence secretary H. C. Sarin's house to bring him up to date and to discuss the plans to defend Assam should the Chinese spill into the plains. But first he telephoned the Military Ops Room in Army HQ, only to be informed that HQ IV Corps had by then reported the actual fall of Bomdila.

After briefing Sarin on the events that had led to the capitulation of Se-la, Dirang Dzong and Bomdila, Palit focused the attention back on Assam. In everyone's perception, Se-la and Dirang Dzong were still deep inside NEFA, while Bomdila was literally the last barrier between the Chinese forces and the rest of India. Even after all these years, it is actually quite amazing as to how such a level of paralysis could have gripped the Indian leadership. Had it just been talk, it would have been understandable, for the further one is from the scene of action, the worse the situation sometimes looks. However, at a time when IV Corps should have resolutely gone about the business of reorganizing the troops, by ordering the evacuation of Tezpur, Kaul and Sen had just given up.

Ever since the fall of Walong, Kaul had been sending frantic messages to Nehru imploring him to ask the United States and Britain to send their air force to stop the Chinese. It perhaps did not even occur to Kaul that India herself had air power that until now had only been used for logistical support. However, it was now Palit's turn to look towards the skies when all else seemed to have failed. He 'impressed upon Sarin that if the fighting spread to the Assam plains, there would be no choice other than to commit the air force, both for ground support roles and interdiction missions in the mountains and on the Tibetan plateau, even if such an extension of the war resulted in Chinese bombers attacking some of our cities'.

Sarin replied that we would use our air force only if we could ensure adequate air defence of our north Indian cities. He then mused, as if thinking aloud, that perhaps we might seek the help of the US or British air force. Palit's cutting remark that we could hardly do that with any justification when we had kept our own fighters on the ground did not elicit any further comment.